STABILITY / UPTIME

ELEVATED

MEMORY LEAK SNOWBALL

A gradual memory leak has been accumulating unnoticed for days. Servers are now restarting every few hours. The team is papering over it with forced restarts — but users are noticing the interruptions and trust is slowly eroding.

Memory leaks exemplify why reactive monitoring is insufficient — by the time the alert fires, the degradation has been accumulating for hours or days. The observability solution is continuous profiling: tracking heap usage, garbage collection frequency, and memory growth trends over time, with alerts on gradual drift rather than only threshold breaches. Tools like Pyroscope, pprof, or commercial APM platforms enable continuous production profiling with minimal overhead. From a DevOps process perspective, this failure mode also highlights the importance of load testing in CI: a memory leak that takes days to manifest under real traffic will often appear in hours under sustained synthetic load.

Slow degradation is insidious. It only becomes urgent when it is already a crisis. Monitoring catches it early.

TEAM DISCUSSION

Would your alerting have caught this before users noticed? Or did a customer report it to you first?